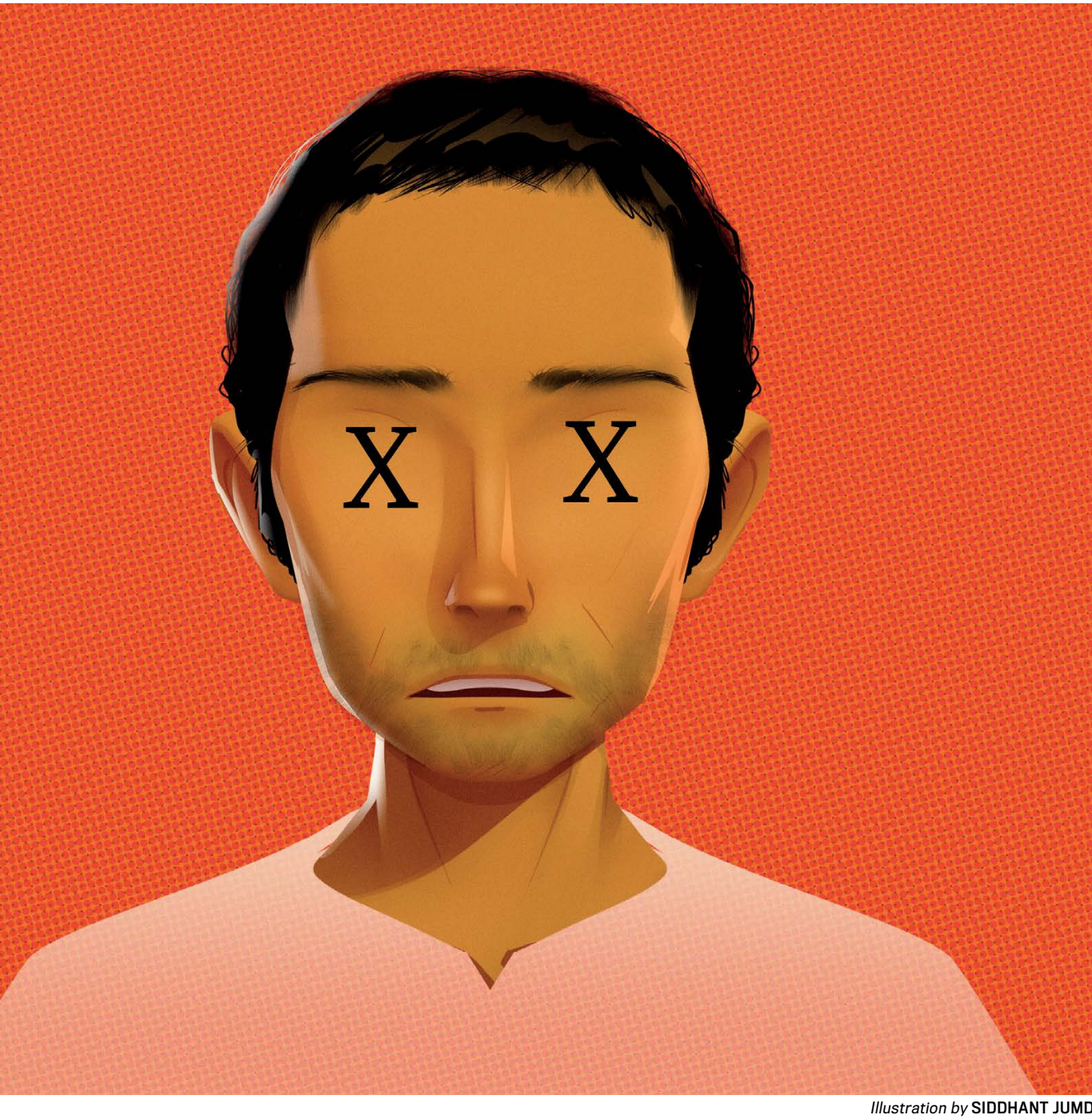


Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

to be an infection caused by a common enough bacteria, Mycoplasma pneumoniae. Officials reasoned the lockdown had lowered immunity against the pathogen and ruled out any threat of another pandemic.

The latest modelling prediction for Disease X comes from London-based disease forecasting company Airfinity, which estimates a 27.5 per cent chance that a pandemic as deadly as Covid-19 could strike by 2033. In a worst-case scenario, Airfinity noted, an outbreak of avian flu transmittable to humans could kill as many as 15,000 people in the UK alone every day. These conclusions are based on 150,000 simulations modelling various potential pathogens, which range in infectiousness, starting outbreak size, population of the country of outbreak and case fatality rate.

Another research by US-based disease risk prediction company Metabiota estimates the annual probability of a pandemic on the scale of Covid-19 in any given year to be between 2.5 and 3.3 per cent, which means a 47-57 per cent chance of another global pandemic as deadly as Covid in the next 25 years. The prediction uses techniques from both epidemiological and catastrophe modelling to estimate the expected impact of future outbreaks, and assesses long-term pandemic risk. The analysis also estimated that preventing just 1 per cent of spillover events (when a virus jumps from one